

He had heard about my plans to retire. "But don't you have a job that pays a lot of money?" he asked. "A job with prestige, security, and plenty of vacation? With a big accounting firm or something?"

I nodded.

"And you're going to quit?"

I began to feel funny, but I nodded again.

"Why would anyone ever quit a good job?" he asked incredulously.

I mumbled something about personal choice and looked away. I felt clobbered. Here was a guy breaking his back to achieve what I already had. If I was doing the wrong thing, after a short time I would be back pounding the pavement like him. His eyes told me I didn't want that to happen.

Later that night I agonized over the decision one more time.

I had started with Peat Marwick in 1972 making something less than \$14,000 a year. I worked hard, got good raises, and became a valued contributor. Now I lived in the best part of town, paid a maid to watch TV, and bought \$500 suits. The future looked so bright I was even thinking of flying first-class on *personal* trips.

Why would I gratuitously give up something I had worked so hard to achieve? I was under no illusions. If after a few years I had to go back to work, I could never get as good a job. I wouldn't have to throw Tupperware parties or drive a Good Humor truck, but I would almost certainly have to take a big cut in pay. At business school we called the top jobs "golden handcuffs." Golden means you have a good job, make good money. Handcuffs means you're tied to it: you'd never be able to make as much money doing something else.

But what kept hammering in my head was that Vicki and I could live without the big income. After converting our assets to cash and investing in CDs we would earn over \$40,000 of interest each year. Under the \$50-a-Day Rule we lived on only \$18,000 a year. The balance would more than cover